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ACADEMIC VAULT

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Nutrition for Students: Eat Well on a Small Budget

Affordable meals that support concentration, energy and health

HEALTH & WELLBEING

Health & Wellbeing

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Cheap food is not automatically bad food, and expensive food is not automatically balanced. This pack explains the basics of a balanced plate, builds affordable Nigerian meal combinations, and covers hydration, food safety and the effects of caffeine and energy drinks.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Explain the components of a balanced diet and their functions.
- Build affordable meals using locally available foods.
- Apply food-safety practices in hostel and shared kitchens.
- Make informed choices about caffeine, sugary drinks and supplements.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

The balanced plate

You do not need imported foods to eat well.

- Carbohydrates provide energy: rice, yam, plantain, garri, maize, potatoes.
- Proteins build and repair tissue: beans, fish, eggs, chicken, milk, groundnuts.
- Fats in moderation support hormones and vitamin absorption: vegetable oil, nuts, avocado.
- Vitamins and minerals come from vegetables and fruit; include something green or orange daily.
- Fibre supports digestion and steady energy: beans, vegetables, whole grains.
- Water is essential; aim for regular intake through the day, more in heat.

Affordable combinations

Balance is about combination, not cost.

- Beans and plantain with vegetables gives carbohydrate, protein and fibre.
- Rice with beans and a vegetable stew is cheap and filling.
- Pap with milk and groundnuts adds protein to a cheap breakfast.
- Eggs are one of the cheapest complete proteins.
- Buy staples in bulk and share with roommates to reduce unit cost.
- Reduce sugary drinks; they add cost and calories without nutrients.

> **Do not skip breakfast before exams**
> Skipping meals reduces concentration and increases irritability. Even a small protein-containing breakfast improves exam performance compared with none.

Safety and stimulants

Food poisoning can cost you a week of lectures.

- Wash hands and produce; separate raw meat from cooked food.
- Cook food thoroughly and refrigerate promptly where possible.
- Be cautious with street food that has been sitting uncovered in heat.
- Treat water carefully if the source is uncertain.
- Caffeine is not a substitute for sleep; energy drinks cause crashes.
- Supplements are not a shortcut to health and can interact with medication.

Energy is a food problem before it is a willpower problem

The afternoon slump, the inability to concentrate at 4 p.m., and the constant hunger that leads to buying whatever is nearest are usually consequences of what was eaten at 7 a.m. - often nothing. A breakfast with protein and fibre produces a slower rise and fall in blood glucose than a sugary drink and a pastry.

The basic composition matters more than any specific diet: carbohydrates for fuel, protein for repair and satiety, fats for hormones and absorption, fibre for digestion and steady energy, and water for everything. Most student diets are high in refined carbohydrate, low in protein and vegetables, and low in water.

Meal timing shapes energy. Three meals with one or two small snacks suits most people better than one huge evening meal, particularly for concentration during the day.

Eating well on a student budget

The cheapest nutrition per naira is usually staples bought dry and in bulk, combined with legumes and seasonal vegetables: rice and beans, yam and egg, garri with groundnut and vegetables, pap with milk, bread with egg. Adding a protein source and a vegetable to a staple transforms its nutritional value for a small cost.

Cook in batches. One pot of beans or stew divided into portions and refrigerated or frozen saves both money and the decision fatigue that leads to buying expensive food. A shared cooking arrangement with housemates reduces cost further.

Water is the cheapest performance enhancer available. Keep a bottle with you and drink before you feel thirsty. Sugary drinks and energy drinks provide a short rise followed by a fall, and the caffeine masks fatigue rather than resolving it.

> **Add, do not subtract**
> Rather than removing foods, add what is missing: a protein source and a vegetable at each main meal. Restriction usually fails; addition usually holds.

Food safety, iron and common deficiencies

Food poisoning is common where water and refrigeration are unreliable. Wash hands and produce, cook meat thoroughly, separate raw and cooked food, refrigerate promptly, and be careful with food left out in heat. Reheating should be thorough, not lukewarm.

Iron deficiency is common in young women and in anyone with a cereal-heavy diet. Plant iron is absorbed better with vitamin C, so pair beans or greens with tomato, citrus or pepper, and avoid tea with meals since it inhibits absorption.

If you are persistently tired despite adequate sleep and food, see the health centre and ask about anaemia, malaria and thyroid function rather than assuming laziness. Fatigue is a symptom, not a character trait.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Rebuilding a typical day

Your current day: no breakfast, soft drink and pastry at 11, rice at 4, instant noodles at 11 p.m.

1. Identify the problems: no protein until evening, long gaps, sugary drink, late heavy meal.
2. Add breakfast: bread with egg, or pap with milk and groundnut.
3. Replace the soft drink with water and a piece of fruit.
4. Add beans or fish to the rice and a vegetable.
5. Move the evening meal earlier and make it lighter.
6. Keep one snack available: groundnut, banana or yoghurt.

> **What to carry forward**
> Three additions and one replacement. Sustainable changes are small and specific.

2. A week's cooking plan

You have a shared kitchen, a small budget and two hours on Sunday.

1. Buy staples dry and in bulk: rice, beans, garri, oil, tomatoes, onions, pepper.
2. Cook a large pot of beans and a tomato stew base.
3. Portion into containers and refrigerate or freeze.
4. Buy vegetables twice a week rather than once, to keep them fresh.
5. Assign two evenings to cooking and use leftovers on the others.
6. Track cost for one week and compare with buying prepared food.

> **What to carry forward**
> Batch cooking converts a budget problem into a time problem, which is easier to solve.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain why breakfast affects concentration during morning lectures.

10 marks

1. Blood glucose supplies the brain.
2. A meal with protein and fibre releases energy slowly.
3. Skipping breakfast produces a later deficit and compensatory overeating.

Q2. How can a student eat a balanced diet on a limited budget?

15 marks

1. Staples bought dry and in bulk.
2. Legumes as affordable protein.
3. Seasonal vegetables and fruit.
4. Batch cooking and shared purchasing.
5. Water instead of sugary drinks.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Macronutrient. A nutrient needed in large amounts: carbohydrate, protein or fat.

Fibre. Indigestible plant material that supports digestion and steady energy.

Blood glucose. The concentration of sugar in the blood, the brain's main fuel.

Legume. A plant in the bean family, an affordable protein source.

Iron deficiency. Insufficient iron for red blood cell production, causing fatigue.

Vitamin C. A nutrient that enhances absorption of plant iron.

Batch cooking. Cooking several portions at once for later meals.

Food safety. Practices preventing foodborne illness.

Satiety. The feeling of fullness that ends eating.

Dehydration. Insufficient body water, impairing concentration and physical performance.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Record

What you actually eat.

- Record everything eaten for three days.
- Note water intake.
- Identify the biggest gap.

Week 2 - Add

Protein and vegetables.

- Add a protein source to each main meal.
- Add one vegetable daily.
- Replace one sugary drink with water.

Week 3 - Cook

Budget and batching.

- Cook two batches of staples.
- Portion and store.
- Compare the weekly cost.

Week 4 - Check

Energy and health.

- Rate afternoon energy daily.
- Review sleep and water.
- See the health centre if fatigue persists.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A basic nutrition guide covering macronutrients and balanced diets.
- A food safety guide for households without reliable refrigeration.
- Your campus health centre's advice on nutrition and anaemia.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the three macronutrients and one function of each.

Answer: Carbohydrates for energy, proteins for growth and repair, and fats for energy storage, hormone production and vitamin absorption.

2. Give an affordable balanced meal using local foods.

Answer: Beans, plantain and vegetables with water; it provides carbohydrate, protein, fibre and micronutrients.

3. Why is skipping breakfast counterproductive before an exam?

Answer: It reduces available energy and concentration, impairing performance.

4. State two food-safety rules.

Answer: Wash hands and produce, and keep raw and cooked foods separate to prevent cross-contamination.

5. What is wrong with relying on energy drinks to study?

Answer: They provide a temporary stimulant effect followed by a crash, and disrupt sleep which is necessary for memory.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] List five affordable protein sources near you.
- [ ] Plan three balanced meals using local staples.
- [ ] Set a daily water intake target.
- [ ] Practise safe food handling for one week.
- [ ] Replace one sugary drink per day with water.
- [ ] Compare the cost of bulk versus single purchases.
- [ ] Track energy levels alongside meals for a week.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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